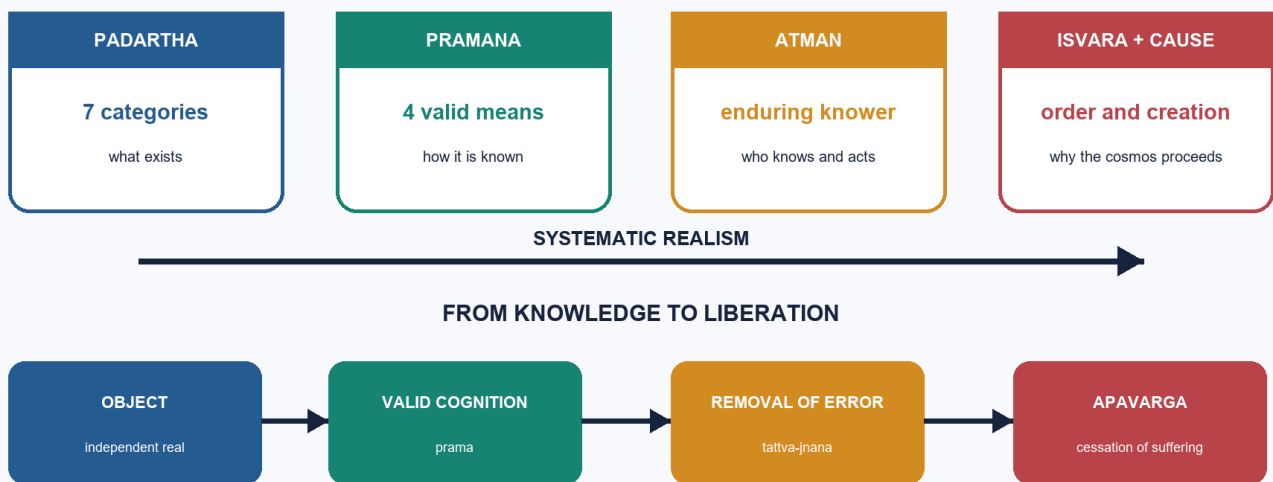


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

NYAYA-VAISESIKA - Syllabus Item 15 (Paper I - Section B)

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

NYAYA-VAISESIKA: REALITY, KNOWLEDGE, ORDER



Causation: asatkaryavada | Relations: samavaya vs samyoga | Creation: eternal atoms under moral order

Original study visual; the diagram organizes the system and does not replace doctrinal distinctions.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

NYAYA-VAISESIKA - Syllabus Item 15 (Paper I - Section B)

15. PYQ ROUTING (2018–2025)

ANALYSIS: **Corpus signal:** 22 primary-owned question-parts out of 112. The local Paper I corpus is continuous from 2018 through 2025. Cross-links do not create duplicate ownership.

Year	Question	Marks	Exact demand
2018	Q5(a)	10 marks	How do the Vaiśeṣika philosophers explain the difference of the relationships in the two cases—(i) the brown colour of the table and (ii) the book on the table? Discuss.
2018	Q5(d)	10 marks	How do the Buddhists and the Nyāya philosophers explain our knowledge of 'the absence of the jar on the table'? Answer in detail.
2018	Q6(a)	20 marks	How do the Naiyāyikas prove the existence of God? Do the Yoga philosophers prove God in the same way? If yes, how? And if no, why? Give reasons for your answer.
2019	Q5(a)	10 marks	Justify the status of Abhāva as a category in Vaiśeṣika philosophy.
2019	Q6(b)	15 marks	What is the role of Jñānalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa in explaining Anyathākhyāti?
2019	Q7(a)	20 marks	How does Udayana prove the existence of God through Kāryāt, Āyojanāt, Dhṛtyādeḥ and Śruteḥ? Discuss.
2020	Q6(c)	15 marks	Explain the concepts of 'Anyathāsiddha' and 'Ananyathāsiddha' in the context of Asatkāryavāda.
2020	Q8(b)	15 marks	Critically evaluate the logical and metaphysical status of Viśeṣa in the context of Vaiśeṣika Philosophy.
2021	Q5(a)	10 marks	Does the seed contain the tree? Discuss with reference to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika Philosophy.
2021	Q5(b)	10 marks	Explain with reference to Nyāya Philosophy, the nature of śabda as the advice of āpta (a reliable person).
2021	Q5(c)	10 marks	Is 'inseparability' (ayuta-siddhatva) a necessary condition or a sufficient condition for defining characteristics (lakṣaṇa) of samavāya (inherence)? Explain with reference to Vaiśeṣika Philosophy.
2022	Q5(b)	10 marks	What is the ontological status of Sāmānya, according to Vaiśeṣika Philosophy? Critically examine.
2022	Q7(c)	15 marks	How do Naiyāyikas respond to Cārvāka's objections against inference (anumāna) and establish inference as an independent means of knowledge? Critically discuss.
2023	Q5(d)	10 marks	Present an account of Vaiśeṣika's view of negation in the light of their statement — "Negation always has a counterpositive and absolute negation is an impossibility."
2023	Q6(c)	15 marks	Elucidate Naiyāyikas view of ordinary and extraordinary perception. Are they justified in accepting that universals are perceived? Discuss.
2023	Q7(a)	20 marks	Elucidate Naiyāyikas account of fallacies of the middle term in relation to five characteristics of valid middle term.
2023	Q8(b)	15 marks	Write a note on Nyāya notion of Prāgabhāva (prior non-existence). How does this notion help Naiyāyikas in defending their position on causation against the Sāṃkhya view of causation? Critically discuss.
2024	Q5(b)	10 marks	Explain the six reasons offered by the Naiyāyikas to prove the existence of the self.
2024	Q5(c)	10 marks	Do these two sentences "Air does not have heat" and "Air is not fire" refer to the same type of absence or abhāva, according to the Vaiśeṣikas? Discuss.
2025	Q5(b)	10 marks	Present an exposition of the debate between Naiyāyikas and Buddhists with reference to the notion of Pramāṇa and Pramāṇaphala.

Year	Question	Marks	Exact demand
2025	Q5(e)	10 marks	Present an exposition of Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika's theory of causation.
2025	Q6(a)	20 marks	Present a detailed account of Gautama's definition of Perception.

See the Indian Philosophy PYQ Bank, 2018–2025.

16. ANSWER ARCHITECTURE (10 / 15 / 20 marks)

16.1 For a 10-marker

Define the term technically.
List its parts/classification.
Add one contrast or one objection.
Close with one line of significance.

16.2 For a 15-marker

Intro: state the problem Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika solves.
Body A: doctrine with technical vocabulary.
Body B: argument or classification.
Body C: one objection and reply / one comparison.
Conclusion: precise evaluative line.

16.3 For a 20-marker

Frame: locate the doctrine in the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika system.
Exposition: full statement with subdivisions.
Analysis: argument structure and presuppositions.
Debate: rival view plus criticism and response.
Verdict: what remains philosophically strong and where difficulty persists.

17. LINK-OUTS

- Buddhism.md — contrast on self, momentariness and pramāṇa.
- Samkhya.md — satkāryavāda contrast.
- Mimamsa.md — svataḥ-prāmāṇya, śabda and akhyāti comparison.
- Vedanta.md — anirvacanīya-khyāti and self-consciousness contrast.
- ../_themes/Pramana-across-schools.md — comparative pramāṇa map.
- ../_themes/Causation-across-schools.md — ārambhavāda in context.
- ../_themes/Self-and-liberation-across-schools.md — ātman and mokṣa contrasts.
- ../_PYQ-Indian-Philosophy-2018-2025.md — Indian Philosophy PYQ bank.
- ../..paper-2/philosophy-of-religion/Proofs-for-God.md — cross-paper theism and critique.

SOURCES

- Gautama, *Nyāya-sūtra*, in standard textbook exposition and paraphrase where exact wording is uncertain.
- Kaṇāda, *Vaiśeṣika-sūtra*, in standard textbook exposition.
- Udayana, *Nyāyakusumāñjali*, for theistic proofs as commonly transmitted in Indian philosophy surveys.
- Chatterjee & Datta, *An Introduction to Indian Philosophy*.
- C.D. Sharma, *A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy*.
- S. Radhakrishnan, *Indian Philosophy*, especially discussion of Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika realism and theism.

CURRENT LINKAGE STATUS

FACT: Search result, 16 August 2026: No fresh official India-wide development specifically concerning Nyaya, Vaisesika, or classical Indian logic was verifiable for February-August 2026. Ongoing Indian Knowledge Systems activity remains a broad educational context, not evidence for any doctrine. This package therefore uses no decorative current-affairs claim.

Direct local source anchors

- FACT: Chatterjee and Datta, local OCR edition, especially file pages 136-170 for Nyaya realism, pramana, perception, inference and testimony.
- FACT: C. D. Sharma, local OCR edition, especially file pages 173-186 for Vaishesika categories, atomism, God and critical evaluation.
- FACT: The repository PYQ bank controls wording, marks and ownership for all 22 questions below.

PART II - SOLVED PYQs, PRACTICE AND ANSWER TRAINING

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 Q5(a), 10 marks

Question: How do the Vaishesika philosophers explain the difference between the brown colour of the table and the book on the table?

Model solution

The brown colour and table stand in **samavaya**; the book and table stand in **samyoga**.

Samavaya is eternal, intimate inherence between inseparably related entities: quality and substance, action and substance, universal and particular, whole and parts, or visesa and eternal substance. Brownness cannot exist independently and then be placed on the table; it inheres in its locus.

Samyoga is conjunction between independently existing substances. The book and table can exist apart, their relation is produced and destructible, and either relatum may move away.

Test	Brown-table	Book-table
Relation	samavaya	samyoga
Relata	quality-substance	substance-substance
Separability	ayutasiddha	yutasiddha
Duration	relation treated as eternal	produced and destructible

Verdict: Vaishesika needs samavaya because conjunction cannot explain the constitutive unity of dependent qualities with substances.

Why this earns marks: It names both relations, gives their ontological tests, applies them to the examples, and states the philosophical need for inherence.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2018 Q5(d), 10 marks

Question: How do Buddhists and Nyaya explain knowledge of "the absence of the jar on the table"?

Model solution

Nyaya-Vaishesika treats **abhava** as a real category. When a competent perceiver apprehends the table under suitable conditions and no jar is present, the non-existence of the jar is directly known. The table is the locus; jar is the **pratiyogin**, the counterpositive whose absence is qualified.

Buddhist analysis avoids a separately existing negative entity. Absence-cognition is explained through the positive perception of the bare locus together with conceptual exclusion, non-apprehension, or inference from failure to perceive an otherwise perceptible jar.

Nyaya argues that the cognition has a determinate object—jar-absence—and cannot be reduced to mere table-perception, because "the table is jarless" differs from simply "this is a table." The Buddhist replies that reifying every meaningful negation needlessly multiplies entities.

Verdict: Nyaya offers ontological realism about absence; Buddhism offers an economical epistemic-conceptual analysis. Nyaya better preserves the intentional object of negative judgement but pays a higher ontological cost.

Why this earns marks: It compares the object, mechanism and philosophical cost of both accounts rather than describing only Nyaya abhava.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2018 Q6(a), 20 marks

Question: How do Naiyayikas prove God? Do Yoga philosophers prove God in the same way?

Model solution

Nyaya infers Isvara as an omniscient, eternal and disembodied efficient cause who arranges eternal atoms, dispenses karmic fruits and grounds authoritative Vedic testimony. The world is an effect composed of parts and exhibiting order; like a pot, it requires an intelligent maker. Atomic conjunction also requires direction, and moral results require an omniscient governor.

The main Nyaya routes are:

karyat → world as effect implies maker
ayojanat → atomic arrangement implies arranger
dhrtyadeh → support and order imply governor
padat → word-meaning convention implies author
pratyayatah → Vedic trustworthiness implies omniscient source
sruteh → scripture testifies to God

Yoga accepts **Isvara**, but its emphasis differs. Patanjali defines Isvara as a special purusa untouched by afflictions, actions, fruits and latent deposits. Isvara is the unsurpassed teacher and an aid to samadhi through Isvara-pranidhana. Classical Yoga does not require Isvara as the material cause and does not develop the same cumulative cosmological-natural-theological proof structure as Udayana.

Nyaya's God coordinates atoms and karma; Yoga's Isvara is primarily a unique spiritual exemplar and meditative support. Later commentators may strengthen Yoga theism, but the doctrinal functions remain distinct.

Objections arise from Samkhya, which sees unconscious prakrti as sufficient; Mimamsa, which regards the Veda as authorless; and the problem of evil. Nyaya replies that atoms and adrsta lack intelligence, authorless sentences cannot establish purposive convention, and God allocates rather than authors karmic desert.

Verdict: Both admit Isvara, but not by the same route or for the same systematic task. Nyaya offers inferential natural theology; Yoga integrates a special purusa into soteriological discipline.

Why this earns marks: It gives Nyaya's proof family, precisely distinguishes Yoga's Isvara, includes rival objections, and answers the comparative demand.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2019 Q5(a), 10 marks

Question: Justify the status of Abhava as a category in Vaisesika philosophy.

Model solution

Abhava is admitted because negative cognitions are objective and irreducible. "There is no jar on the floor" is not merely cognition of the floor; it presents the floor as qualified by jar-absence.

The four forms are:

Abhava	Meaning
Pragabhava	prior absence before production
Pradhvamsabhava	posterior absence after destruction
Atyantabhava	absolute absence between incompatible entities
Anyonyabhava	mutual absence or difference

Every absence has a locus and counterpositive. This prevents "nothing" from becoming an independent void. Abhava is nameable, knowable and explanatorily necessary, so it satisfies the broad padartha criterion.

Critics object that absence is only failure to perceive. Nyaya replies that non-apprehension under adequate conditions yields a positive, determinate judgement about what is absent and where.

Why this earns marks: It justifies rather than merely lists abhava, gives the fourfold classification, and addresses the reduction-to-non-perception objection.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2019 Q6(b), 15 marks

Question: What is the role of Jñanalaksana-pratyaksa in explaining Anyathakhyati?

Model solution

Anyathakhyati explains illusion as mislocation of a real property: in "this is silver," the presented shell is perceived here, while real silver remembered from elsewhere supplies silverness. Error joins two real elements in a false relation.

Jñanalaksana-pratyaksa is extraordinary perception in which prior cognition functions as a special mediator. The present shell triggers memory of silver; through cognition-mediated contact, silverness is presented as belonging to the shell.

visual contact with shell
↓
revival of prior silver-cognition
↓
cognition-mediated presentation of silverness
↓
"this shell is silver"

It explains why illusion feels perceptual rather than like detached memory. The defect lies not in the existence of the relata but in their predicative synthesis.

Advaita objects that absent silver cannot be perceptually related to the present locus; Yogacara questions the external realist framework. Nyaya replies that extraordinary contact is required precisely to explain cross-locational presentation without inventing an indescribable object.

Verdict: Jñanalaksana is the epistemic mechanism that makes anyathakhyati a realist error theory, though critics may see it as an ad hoc extension of perception.

Why this earns marks: It separates the theory of error from its perceptual mechanism, gives the causal sequence, and adds the strongest criticism.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2019 Q7(a), 20 marks

Question: How does Udayana prove God through Karyat, Ayojanat, Dhṛtyadeh and Sruteh?

Model solution

Udayana's proofs form a cumulative explanation of production, arrangement, stability and authoritative revelation.

Karyat: The world is an effect because it is composite, mutable and dependent. Effects such as pots require intelligent makers; therefore the world requires an omniscient maker. God is efficient, not material, cause because eternal atoms supply material.

Ayojanat: Atoms are inert and adrsta is non-conscious. Their purposive initial conjunction into dyads and complex bodies requires intelligent direction.

Dhṛtyadeh: The world's continued support, coordinated order and dissolution require a governor. Natural regularity and the allocation of karmic fruits are not explained by blind matter alone.

Sruteh: Scripture testifies to God. Nyaya supplements this with the argument that reliable Vedic discourse requires an omniscient source; sentencehood and authority are difficult to ground in an authorless text.

The proofs presuppose that order is explanatory evidence of intelligence, unconscious causes cannot organize themselves teleologically, and testimony ultimately depends on a trustworthy speaker.

Samkhya argues that prakṛti suffices; Mimamsa defends an authorless Veda; Buddhists reject permanent creator and atoms. Nyaya replies that unconscious prakṛti or adrsta cannot select morally fitted outcomes, while an omniscient governor coordinates pre-existing materials and karmic law.

The problem of evil remains: if God is omnipotent and benevolent, suffering is difficult. Nyaya treats God as impartial administrator of beginningless karma, though the critic may ask why such a system is sustained.

Verdict: Udayana is strongest when read cumulatively: no single analogy demonstrates God, but maker, arranger, sustainer and authoritative speaker jointly form Nyaya's best explanation.

Why this earns marks: It explains each named proof, exposes presuppositions, handles three rival schools and gives a graded evaluation.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2020 Q6(c), 15 marks

Question: Explain Anyathasiddha and Ananyathasiddha in the context of Asatkaryavada.

Model solution

Nyaya defines a cause as an **ananyathasiddha** antecedent: an indispensable prior condition whose relevance to the effect cannot be explained otherwise. Mere temporal priority is insufficient, because countless earlier events are causally irrelevant.

An **anyathasiddha** antecedent is otherwise established or irrelevant to production. The potter's father precedes the pot but is not its cause; the colour of the stick used in making a pot is incidental to its productive role.

The distinction disciplines **asatkaryavada**, according to which the effect is a new beginning. A pot does not pre-exist in clay, yet its production is not ex nihilo: clay, conjunction, potter and instruments are causally necessary in distinct ways.

Nyaya distinguishes:

Cause	Example in pot
Samavayi	clay/parts inhering in effect
Asamavayi	conjunction or qualities inhering in material cause
Nimitta	potter, wheel and instruments

Only relevant indispensable antecedents enter the causal set. Critics ask whether indispensability is discovered without already knowing causal laws. Nyaya answers through repeated observation, elimination of conditions and explanatory analysis.

Verdict: The pair prevents arambhavada from collapsing into the claim that every antecedent causes every later event.

Why this earns marks: It defines both terms, applies them, links them to the three causes, and states their role in securing disciplined new-production theory.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2020 Q8(b), 15 marks

Question: Critically evaluate the logical and metaphysical status of Visesa.

Model solution

Visesa is ultimate particularity, admitted to distinguish numerically different eternal substances that share all general properties: atoms of one element, selves, minds, time, space and ether. Compound objects differ through parts and qualities; indiscernible eternal simples require a primitive differentiator.

Logically, visesa grounds numerical distinction where qualitative criteria fail. Metaphysically, it is eternal, innumerable, resident by samavaya in eternal substances, and self-differentiating.

The main objection is regress: if visesa differentiates atoms, what differentiates one visesa from another? Vaisesika replies that visesas are **svato-vyavrtta**, self-excluding; demanding another differentiator misunderstands their primitive function.

A second objection calls visesa an ontological IOU—an imperceptible entity postulated only to save plurality. The realist reply is abductive: if multiple eternal reals are required by causal and moral explanation, a principle of

individuation is unavoidable.

Verdict: Visesa is logically intelligible as primitive thisness, but its metaphysical force depends on prior commitment to plural eternal substances. It completes the system more than it independently proves itself.

Why this earns marks: It covers function, locus, regress, self-differentiation and the deeper dependence of visesa on realist pluralism.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2021 Q5(a), 10 marks

Question: Does the seed contain the tree? Discuss with reference to Nyaya-Vaisesika.

Model solution

No. Nyaya-Vaisesika defends **asatkaryavada**: the effect does not pre-exist as an actual effect in its material cause. The tree is a new product, although its production depends on seed-material, water, soil, heat and other conditions.

If the tree already existed in the seed, production would be redundant; the distinction between cause and effect would collapse; and the same effect should be available without the complete causal complex. The seed possesses capacity, not a concealed tree.

The relation is explained through prior absence:

pragabhava of tree + complete causal conditions
↓
new production of tree
↓
destruction may yield pradhvamsabhava

Samkhya objects that what is absolutely non-existent cannot arise. Nyaya replies that "non-existent before production" means prior absence in the cause, not impossibility like a hare's horn.

Why this earns marks: It states the exact doctrine, distinguishes capacity from pre-existence, uses pragabhava and answers the Samkhya objection.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2021 Q5(b), 10 marks

Question: Explain sabda as the advice of apta.

Model solution

Sabda is valid verbal testimony, classically defined as the statement or instruction of an **apta**—a competent and trustworthy speaker who knows the fact and communicates it without intention to deceive.

Its validity requires:

1. a reliable speaker;
2. meaningful words governed by convention;
3. syntactic expectancy, compatibility and proximity;
4. a hearer who understands the sentence;
5. absence of defeating conditions.

Testimony is independent because much knowledge—history, distant places, specialized science and ordinary social facts—cannot be reconstructed by each hearer through direct perception or inference. The hearer may infer the speaker's reliability, but sentence-understanding yields its object through linguistic cognition.

Vedic testimony is treated as supremely reliable through divine or omniscient authorship in Nyaya. Mimamsa instead grounds Vedic authority in authorlessness.

Why this earns marks: It defines apta, states conditions of verbal cognition, justifies independent pramana status, and adds the Nyaya-Mimamsa contrast.

Solved PYQ 11 - 2021 Q5(c), 10 marks

Question: Is ayutasiddhatva a necessary or sufficient condition for samavaya?

Model solution

Ayutasiddhatva means inseparability: one relatum cannot exist independently in the relevant way from the other. It is necessary for samavaya because inherence connects whole-parts, quality-substance, action-substance, universal-instance and visesa-eternal substance.

It is not by itself sufficient. Mere inseparability can arise from other facts, and samavaya requires a distinctive constitutive relation between ontologically dependent relata. The relation must also be non-conjunctive, intimate and not produced like samyoga.

For example, colour cannot exist without some substance, and this supports inherence. But two tightly joined physical objects may be practically inseparable while remaining connected only by conjunction.

The regress objection asks whether samavaya needs another relation to connect it to its relata. Vaisesika stops the regress by treating samavaya as self-linking and sui generis.

Verdict: Ayutasiddhatva is a necessary diagnostic but not a complete sufficient definition unless supplemented by the specific locus-relatum structure of inherence.

Why this earns marks: It directly answers necessary versus sufficient, uses examples, and shows why the definition needs supplementation.

Solved PYQ 12 - 2022 Q5(b), 10 marks

Question: What is the ontological status of Samanya according to Vaisesika? Critically examine.

Model solution

Samanya is a real, eternal universal, one in many, inhering in substances, qualities or actions. Cow-ness is not merely a word or mental image; it objectively grounds common predication and classification across individual cows.

Universals form higher and lower orders: *satta* or being is maximally general, while cow-ness is restricted. Samanya is related to instances by samavaya.

Buddhist apoha theory objects that commonness can be explained by exclusion of non-cows without a universal. A further problem asks how one entity is wholly present in many places. Vaisesika replies that a universal is non-spatially one and multiply instantiated, not physically divided.

The six jati-badhakas restrict indiscriminate multiplication of universals, showing that Vaisesika realism is disciplined rather than unlimited.

Verdict: Samanya gives a robust basis for classification and inference, but its independent reality is less economical than nominalist or exclusion accounts.

Why this earns marks: It states samanya's full ontological profile, relation to particulars, internal restrictions, and the Buddhist challenge.

Solved PYQ 13 - 2022 Q7(c), 15 marks

Question: How do Naiyayikas answer Carvaka objections to inference and establish anumana as an independent pramana?

Model solution

Carvaka argues that inference depends on **vyapti**, universal concomitance, which cannot be known. Perception covers only finite cases; inference used to establish vyapti becomes circular; and hidden conditions may produce exceptions.

Nyaya replies that vyapti is not an a priori leap. It is secured through repeated agreement in presence and absence, absence of counter-instance, elimination of **upadhi**, and **tarka**:

bhuyodarsana + vyabhicara-adarsana
+ upadhi-nirasa + tarka

↓
qualified grasp of vyapti
↓
paramarsa
↓
inferential cognition

Inference is indispensable even to Carvaka criticism. To claim that unobserved cases may differ is itself an inferential generalization. Everyday action—fire from smoke, danger from signs, another mind from behaviour—also presupposes reliable transition beyond perception.

Nyaya does not claim infallible induction from a small sample. Vyapti is fallible in discovery but corrigible through counterexamples and condition-analysis. Once correctly known and applied through paksa-dharmata and paramarsa, it produces new knowledge.

Verdict: Nyaya defeats global scepticism about inference, though its account of universal necessity remains vulnerable to the Humean problem that observed regularity does not logically compel all unobserved cases.

Why this earns marks: It reconstructs Carvaka's strongest objections, explains the complete Nyaya method, exposes performative dependence, and offers a critical verdict.

Solved PYQ 14 - 2023 Q5(d), 10 marks

Question: Explain the claim that negation always has a counterpositive and absolute negation is impossible.

Model solution

An absence is always the absence **of something** in a locus. The absent entity is the **pratiyogin** or counterpositive; the place where it is absent is the **anuyogin** or locus. "There is no jar on the floor" means jar-absence qualified by the floor.

Absolute featureless nothing cannot be cognized, named or distinguished. Even **atyantabhava**, often translated absolute absence, remains relational: colour is absent from air at all times, or a hare's horn is absent as a possible entity, relative to a specified counterpositive.

Mutual absence explains difference: a pot is not cloth and cloth is not pot. Prior and posterior absences explain before-production and after-destruction.

Verdict: Vaisesika negation is relationally realist, not commitment to an independent Nothing. Its strength is logical determinacy; its cost is treating negative facts as ontological entities.

Why this earns marks: It explains counterpositive and locus, clarifies atyantabhava, and connects the claim to all major forms of absence.

Solved PYQ 15 - 2023 Q6(c), 15 marks

Question: Explain ordinary and extraordinary perception. Are Naiyayikas justified in accepting that universals are perceived?

Model solution

Ordinary perception (**laukika**) arises through normal sense-object contact and includes external perception through five senses and internal perception through manas. Nyaya analyses six modes of contact, such as conjunction, inherence in the conjoined, and inherence of a universal in a quality.

Extraordinary perception (**alaukika**) has three forms:

1. **Samanyalaksana:** perception of many or all instances through a perceived universal.
2. **Jnanalaksana:** prior cognition mediates presentation, as in seeing fragrant sandalwood or illusory silver.
3. **Yogaja:** extraordinary perception generated by yogic discipline.

Nyaya justifies universal-perception by arguing that recognition "this is a cow" includes direct awareness of cow-ness; otherwise classification and vyapti would lack objective grounding. Samanyalaksana also helps explain knowledge extending beyond presently sensed particulars.

Buddhists object that perception is of unique particulars and universals are conceptual constructions. The Nyaya account risks making perception too intellectual and overextending it to unobserved members.

Verdict: Ordinary perception is plausible realism; samanyalaksana is systematically useful but the least secure form because it blurs perception and conceptual generalization.

Why this earns marks: It gives the complete classification, explains the universal argument, and critically distinguishes the stronger and weaker parts.

Solved PYQ 16 - 2023 Q7(a), 20 marks

Question: Explain fallacies of the middle term in relation to five characteristics of a valid middle term.

Model solution

A valid **hetu** must satisfy five marks:

1. **Paksadharmata:** present in the subject.
2. **Sapakasasattva:** present in positive instances where the probandum occurs.
3. **Vipakasasattvabhava:** absent in negative instances.
4. **Abadhitatva:** not contradicted by stronger knowledge.
5. **Asatpratipaksatva:** not opposed by an equally strong counter-reason.

Hetvabhasas arise when these conditions fail:

Fallacy	Defect	Illustration
Savyabhicara	irregular reason; fails concomitance	hill has fire because knowable
Viruddha	reason proves opposite	sound is eternal because produced
Satpratipaksa	counterbalanced reason	opposing valid-looking hetu
Asiddha	reason unestablished in paksa	sky-lotus is fragrant because lotus
Badhita	contradicted by stronger cognition	fire is cold because substance

Some classifications align subtypes differently, but the logical core is failure of subject-presence, positive/negative concomitance, undefeatedness or non-opposition.

The fallacy doctrine is not merely a list. It is the negative mirror of **vyapti**: each apparent reason reveals how inference fails when the middle term does not reliably connect paksa and sadhya.

Critically, Nyaya combines formal and material relevance. It does not validate an argument by form alone; the reason must be objectively connected with the property proved. This strengthens empirical reasoning but makes validity depend on a substantive account of universal relation.

Verdict: The five characteristics and five fallacies form a rigorous diagnostic system, though their success ultimately depends on the contested possibility of knowing vyapti.

Why this earns marks: It lists all marks and fallacies, maps defects to conditions, and explains their unity through vyapti rather than rote taxonomy.

Solved PYQ 17 - 2023 Q8(b), 15 marks

Question: Explain Pragabhava and how it helps Nyaya defend causation against Samkhya.

Model solution

Pragabhava is the beginningless prior absence of an effect in its material cause before production. It has no beginning but ends when the effect arises. Pot-absence exists in clay before pot-production.

This supports **asatkaryavada**: the effect as effect is not already actual in the cause. Production terminates its prior absence and begins a new composite entity.

Nyaya argues against Samkhya:

1. If the effect already exists, production is redundant.
2. Cause and effect become indistinguishable.
3. The need for instruments and agents is unexplained.
4. We ordinarily judge "the pot did not exist; now it exists."

Samkhya replies that non-being cannot become being and that a specific cause produces only a specific effect because the effect is latent. Nyaya distinguishes prior absence from absolute impossibility. The pot is absent as an actual whole but possible because appropriate material and causal capacities exist.

Verdict: Pragabhava gives arambhavada a precise temporal ontology. It explains novelty better than latent-effect theory, but still depends on the controversial realism of absences and wholes.

Why this earns marks: It defines temporal structure, derives asatkaryavada, reconstructs both schools, and gives a balanced evaluation.

Solved PYQ 18 - 2024 Q5(b), 10 marks

Question: Explain the six reasons offered by Naiyayikas to prove the self.

Model solution

Nyaya infers an enduring self as the substance possessing cognition, desire, aversion, effort, pleasure, pain, merit and demerit.

Six common routes are:

1. **Memory:** one subject connects past experience and present recollection.
2. **Recognition:** "this is the same" presupposes continuity.
3. **Desire:** present striving refers to previously experienced satisfaction.
4. **Coordination of senses:** one knower integrates colour, touch and taste.
5. **Agency and moral desert:** one agent owns action and fruit.
6. **Possessive awareness:** "I know," "I am happy" presents qualities as belonging to a subject.

Body, senses and manas cannot alone be self: the body changes, senses are multiple instruments, and atomic manas coordinates only one cognition at a time.

Buddhists explain these through causal streams. Nyaya replies that succession explains transmission but not ownership and cross-modal unity.

Why this earns marks: It provides six distinct arguments, identifies self as substance of mental qualities, and adds the Buddhist challenge.

Solved PYQ 19 - 2024 Q5(c), 10 marks

Question: Do "Air does not have heat" and "Air is not fire" refer to the same type of absence?

Model solution

No. "Air does not have heat" expresses **atyantabhava** of the quality heat in air: heat is absent from air across times under the school's elemental classification.

"Air is not fire" expresses **anyonyabhava**, mutual absence or difference. Air is non-fire, just as fire is non-air; one entity is absent as the identity of the other.

Sentence	Absence	Counterpositive
Air lacks heat	atyantabhava	heat
Air is not fire	anyonyabhava	fire as identical with air

The first denies a property in a locus; the second denies identity between substances. Both require a counterpositive, but their relational structures differ.

Why this earns marks: It identifies each absence, explains property-negation versus identity-negation, and uses counterpositive analysis.

Solved PYQ 20 - 2025 Q5(b), 10 marks

Question: Present the debate between Naiyayikas and Buddhists on Pramana and Pramanaphala.

Model solution

Nyaya distinguishes **pramana**, the instrument or operative cause of valid cognition, from **pramanaphala**, its result. In perception, sense-object contact and the cognitive process generate a true cognition whose practical result may be acceptance, rejection or indifference.

Buddhist epistemologists, especially Dharmakirti's tradition, treat pramana and result as non-different phases of one cognition. A cognition is authoritative by manifesting an object-form and enabling successful activity; no separate enduring knower or instrument-substance is needed.

Nyaya argues that instrument and result must be distinguished to preserve causal explanation: an axe is not the cutting-result. Buddhists reply that cognition is self-performing and self-disclosing; splitting it creates unnecessary entities and temporal gaps.

Verdict: Nyaya offers a richer causal analysis; Buddhism offers event-economy. The dispute reflects their larger contrast between substance realism and momentary cognition.

Why this earns marks: It clearly states both positions, gives the causal analogy and links the epistemic dispute to their ontologies.

Solved PYQ 21 - 2025 Q5(e), 10 marks

Question: Present Nyaya-Vaisesika's theory of causation.

Model solution

Nyaya-Vaisesika defends **asatkaryavada** or **arambhavada**: the effect does not pre-exist as an actual effect in its cause; it is newly produced when an indispensable causal complex operates.

Three causes are distinguished:

Cause	Function	Pot example
Samavayi	material/inherent cause	clay or constituent parts
Asamavayi	qualities/relations inhering in material cause	conjunction of clay-parts
Nimitta	efficient occasion	potter, wheel, stick

A cause is an *ananyathasiddha* antecedent, not merely anything earlier. Production terminates *pragabhava*. The effect is a real whole inhering in its parts, not merely a collection.

Samkhya objects that non-being cannot arise. Nyaya replies that prior non-existence differs from absolute impossibility and that causal capacity explains determinate production.

Why this earns marks: It states the doctrine, three causes, relevance condition, *pragabhava* and the principal rival objection.

Solved PYQ 22 - 2025 Q6(a), 20 marks

Question: Present a detailed account of Gautama's definition of Perception.

Model solution

Gautama defines perception as cognition produced by sense-object contact, **avyapadesya**, **avyabhicari** and **vyavasayatmaka**. Each clause excludes a rival defect.

Indriyarthasannikarsotpanna: Perception is generated by contact between sense and object. External senses apprehend their proper objects; manas mediates internal states.

Avyapadesya: It is not essentially produced by verbal testimony. The clause protects direct presentation from dependence on words and is often associated with the non-conceptual phase.

Avyabhicari: It is non-errant. Illusion caused by defect is not valid perception or prama.

Vyavasayatmaka: It is determinate or definite, excluding doubt. Later Nyaya distinguishes **nirvikalpaka** indeterminate awareness from **savikalpaka** qualified judgement and interprets the definition accordingly.

Ordinary perception includes six contact-relations and external/internal forms. Extraordinary perception includes samanyalakšana, jñanalakšana and yogaja.

Criticisms arise. Buddhists deny conceptual perception of universals; Advaita treats some ordinary cognitions as superimposed; modern critics question extraordinary perception. Nyaya replies that recognition, classification, cross-modal illusion and yogic testimony require a wider contact theory.

The definition also faces a circularity concern: if perception is defined as unerring cognition, how is truth known? Nyaya uses **paratah-pramanya**—validity is established through successful activity and subsequent cognition, not built into mere subjective certainty.

Verdict: Gautama's definition systematically excludes testimony, error and doubt while grounding perception in realism. Its ordinary core is strong; its extraordinary extensions are more contestable.

Why this earns marks: It analyses every clause, integrates later classifications, adds validity theory and critically separates ordinary from extraordinary perception.

Integrated MCQ Loop - 24 Questions

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
1	Classical Vaisesika finally recognizes: A. seven padarthas B. four padarthas C. sixteen padarthas D. twenty-four padarthas	A	Dravya, guna, karma, samanya, visesa, samavaya and abhava.
2	Cognition is classified as a quality of: A. manas B. atman C. akasa D. kala	B	Consciousness is a guna of self, not its essence.
3	The relation between colour and substance is: A. samyoga B. svarupa C. samavaya D. tadatmya	C	A quality inheres inseparably in substance.
4	Mutual absence is called: A. pragabhava B. pradhvamsabhava C. atyantabhava D. anyonyabhava	D	It grounds difference such as pot is not cloth.
5	Nyaya admits which pramanas? A. perception, inference, comparison, testimony B. perception alone C. six including arthapatti D. three including anupalabdhi	A	These are the standard four.
6	The cognition immediately responsible for inferential knowledge is: A. samsaya B. paramarsa C. smriti D. tarka alone	B	Paramarsa applies vyapti-qualified hetu to the paksa.
7	Failure of positive concomitance produces a defect in: A. paksadharmata B. abadhitatva C. sapaksasattva D. asatpratipaksatva	C	A valid reason must occur in positive instances.
8	Jnanalaksana is a form of: A. inference B. testimony C. ordinary perception D. extraordinary perception	D	Prior cognition mediates an unusual presentation.
9	Sabda is valid when issued by: A. apta B. any speaker C. only a Vedic priest D. an anonymous source	A	Apta is competent and trustworthy.
10	Anyathakhyati explains error as: A. non-apprehension B. mislocation of a real property C. creation of unreal object D. indescribable appearance	B	Real shell and real silverness are falsely synthesized.
11	The self is inferred as substance of: A. atoms B. universals C. cognition, desire and effort D. sound alone	C	Mental states are qualities requiring a locus.
12	Nyaya liberation is primarily: A. eternal pleasure B. union with Brahman C. heavenly embodiment D. cessation of suffering and its causes	D	Apavarga is release from pain, karma and cognition-producing embodiment.
13	Karyat argues to God from: A. world as effect B. Vedic eternity C. yogic perception D. moral intuition alone	A	A composite effect points to intelligent maker.
14	Ayojanat concerns: A. word meaning B. atomic combination C. memory D. universals	B	Inert atoms require intelligent arrangement.
15	Nyaya causation is: A. satkaryavada B. vivartavada C. asatkaryavada D. svabhavavada	C	Effect is newly produced.
16	The inherent/material cause of a pot is: A. potter B. wheel C. conjunction alone D. clay	D	Clay is samavayi cause.
17	Prior absence is: A. pragabhava B. anyonyabhava C. samavaya D. pradhvamsabhava	A	It ends when the effect is produced.
18	Ultimate differentiator of eternal simples is: A. samanya B. visesa C. guna D. karma	B	Visesa individuates atoms and selves.
19	Vaibhasika criticism is most relevant to Nyaya's: A. God only B. testimony only C. enduring substances and universals D. Yoga practice	C	Buddhist realism still rejects Nyaya's enduring category structure.

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
20	A cause merely earlier but irrelevant is: A. ananyathasiddha B. nimitta C. samavayi D. anyathasiddha	D	Temporal priority alone is insufficient.
21	The five-member inference begins with: A. pratijna B. hetu C. udaharana D. upanaya	A	Thesis precedes reason, example, application and conclusion.
22	An unestablished middle is: A. viruddha B. asiddha C. badhita D. savyabhicara	B	The reason is not established in the subject.
23	Nyaya validity is generally known: A. intrinsically only B. by revelation C. extrinsically through confirming conditions D. never	C	Paratah-pramanya uses successful activity and subsequent cognition.
24	Vaisesika atomism treats atoms as: A. produced wholes B. qualitatively identical C. mental constructions D. eternal, partless and element-specific	D	Earth, water, fire and air atoms have distinct qualities.

Remedial MCQ Loop - 8 Questions

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
25	Samyoga differs from samavaya because it is: A. produced between separable substances B. eternal and intimate C. a universal D. an absence	A	Conjunction can arise and cease.
26	"Air is not fire" exemplifies: A. atyantabhava B. anyonyabhava C. pragabhava D. pradhvamsabhava	B	It denies identity between substances.
27	Samanyalaksana is controversial because it claims: A. words are perceived B. God is directly seen C. universals mediate perception beyond a sensed individual D. all memory is false	C	It stretches perception toward class-wide awareness.
28	Which is not a Nyaya cause-type? A. samavayi B. asamavayi C. nimitta D. upadana as a separate fourth cause	D	Material cause is handled under samavayi.
29	The strongest Carvaka objection to inference targets: A. knowledge of vyapti B. existence of senses C. linguistic convention D. self-consciousness	A	Finite observation cannot trivially establish universal concomitance.
30	Visesa stops regress by being: A. a universal B. self-differentiating C. a quality of compounds D. perceptible colour	B	It is treated as primitive thisness.
31	Yoga's Isvara differs from Nyaya's God because Yoga stresses: A. material creation B. Vedic authorship C. special purusa and meditative aid D. atom arrangement only	C	Its primary function is soteriological.
32	Best overall verdict: A. Nyaya is only formal logic B. Vaisesika denies external reality C. samavaya is ordinary conjunction D. the synthesis is rigorous realism, though primitive relations and theism remain contested	D	This captures both achievement and pressure points.

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Why does Nyaya-Vaisesika require both samavaya and samyoga?

Model solution

Samyoga explains contingent contact between independently existing substances; samavaya explains constitutive unity where one relatum cannot exist independently in the relevant manner. A book rests on a table by conjunction, while colour inheres in the table, a whole inheres in parts, and a universal inheres in instances.

Reducing inference to conjunction would make qualities and wholes detachable substances. Reducing conjunction to inference would make every accidental contact eternal. The distinction therefore protects both ontological dependence and change.

Verdict: The pair is systematic, though samavaya invites regress because an unexplained primitive relation is used to explain relatedness.

Why this earns marks: It uses exact examples, shows why neither relation can replace the other, and includes the core criticism.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 15 marks

Question: Is Nyaya's theory of pramana best understood as realism disciplined by fallibilism?

Model solution

Nyaya is realist because cognition discloses mind-independent objects and truth consists in presenting an object as it is. Perception, inference, comparison and testimony are objective routes to prama.

It is disciplined because not every cognition is valid. Doubt, error and memory are separated from fresh true cognition; inference requires five hetu-marks; testimony requires apta; perception excludes error and doubt. Validity is generally established extrinsically through successful activity and absence of defeaters.

This produces a fallibilist structure: human cognitions can be tested, corrected and defeated. Yet Nyaya sometimes overextends realism through extraordinary perception, real universals and ontological absences.

Verdict: Nyaya is not naive realism. Its strength lies in coupling external objects with elaborate error-diagnostics, though some metaphysical commitments exceed what those diagnostics establish.

Why this earns marks: It interprets the whole epistemology rather than listing pramanas and gives a balanced thesis-driven answer.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 20 marks

Question: "Nyaya-Vaisesika achieves systematic completeness by multiplying primitive entities." Critically examine.

Model solution

The system's achievement is remarkable. Seven padarthas classify positive and negative reality; four pramanas explain knowledge; anyathakhyati preserves realism about error; atman secures continuity; Isvara and adrsta coordinate moral-cosmic order; arambhavada and atoms explain production.

Completeness, however, relies on primitives. Samavaya is a self-linking relation introduced to stop regress. Visesa is self-differentiating particularity introduced to individuate otherwise identical eternals. Universals are objective entities; absences are real; atomic manas coordinates cognition; God directs atoms and karma.

The defender replies that every ontology ends with primitives. The relevant test is explanatory economy, not elimination of basic entities. Samavaya unifies several dependence-relations, visesa secures plurality, and abhava explains determinate negative judgement.

Critics answer that a single label may redescribe rather than explain a problem. Buddhist process theory avoids enduring substances; Mimamsa avoids divine authorship; nominalist approaches avoid universals. Nyaya's response is abductive: its package best preserves common-sense realism, inference, language, identity and responsibility together.

Verdict: The charge is partly justified. Nyaya-Vaisesika's primitives make it systematic, but their value depends on whether unified explanatory coverage outweighs ontological cost. Its greatest strength and weakness are the same—refusal to leave any cognitive or worldly distinction without a realist correlate.

Why this earns marks: It evaluates the system as a whole, names the principal primitives, gives the realist defence, compares rival economies, and reaches a graded verdict.